

Lamine Yamal opened the scoring for Barcelona against Rayo with a penalty in the 40th minute, but Hansi Flick's men could not defend their lead as Fran Perez equalised in the 67th.

Meanwhile, Atletico Madrid continued to struggle. After a 1-1 draw against Elche in its previous game week, Diego Simeone's side was held to another draw by Alaves, again 1-1.

Among the Basque clubs, Athletic had the better week, beating Real Betis 1-0, while Real Sociedad suffered a shock 0-1 loss to newly-promoted Oviedo.

For Sevilla, it was a simple day at office as it beat Girona 2-0.

At the end of Matchday 3, Real Madrid tops the table with nine points. Athletic is second with the same tally but an inferior goal difference. Villarreal and Barcelona occupy third and fourth respectively with seven points each, while Atletico Madrid, yet to win a match, languish in 17th with two points.

FIFA World Cup qualifiers

Football had dealt Lionel Messi a cruel hand for much of his career in Argentina's colours. But by the time he donned the blue and white shirt for possibly the last time on home soil, he was both continental and world champion.

Fans flocked to the capital to get one last look at their hero as Argentina hosted Venezuela in its final home qualifier for the 2026 FIFA World Cup. In true Messi fashion, he delivered, netting twice in a 3-0 win to give his faithful supporters the perfect parting gift.

Now, they await his decision on whether he will lead Argentina's World Cup defence next year.

Brazil enjoyed a bright start to its international window, easing past Chile 3-0 with Chelsea teenager Estevao scoring his first senior international goal. Uruguay, Colombia and Paraguay also booked their places, with Paraguay qualifying for the first time since 2010.

Meanwhile, Messi's ageless counterpart Cristiano Ronaldo also



Road to 2026: Lionel Messi played his last home game in nationals colours, as Argentina beat Venezuela 3-0. **Below:** Cristiano Ronaldo scored twice in Portugal's 5-0 thumping of Armenia. AFP

showed his class. The 40-year-old scored twice as Portugal thumped Armenia 5-0 in their qualifying fixture. The brace took his international goal tally to 140, while his career numbers rose to a staggering 942.

The most shocking result of the break came when Germany, succumbed to a 2-0 loss against Slovakia, its first-ever World Cup qualifier loss on the road. On the contrary, Euro 2024 finalists Spain and England both won comfortably, beating Bulgaria and Andorra

respectively.

Notably, France captain Kylian Mbappe scored his 51st international goal in a 2-0 win over Ukraine, equalling Thierry Henry's tally and closing in on Olivier Giroud's all-time record of 57 international goals for France.

Meanwhile, 2022 World Cup semifinalist Morocco became the first African team to qualify for the global showpiece after thrashing Niger 5-0.

**All results updated
as of September 7**

